

TLP:CLEAR

A Telegram Username-Buyout Pretext Aimed at a Security Researcher

Anatomy of a Fragment-bypass social engineering scheme and the contact indicators behind it

Social Engineering | Account Takeover | Telegram | Pretexting

Parameter	Value
Contact date	August 20, 2026
Classification	TLP:CLEAR
Type	Social Engineering / Account Targeting (pretexting)
Threat level	MEDIUM
Target	A security researcher affiliated with our organization (public Telegram identifier)
Contact source	@BlockRider454 (Telegram, Premium, registered April 2026)
Compromise	Not confirmed — contact stopped at the initial offer stage

1. Summary

On August 20, 2026, a Telegram account belonging to a security researcher affiliated with our organization received an unsolicited message from the account @BlockRider454 offering to buy the researcher's username. The deal was proposed outside Fragment, the official Telegram marketplace for trading usernames. The researcher declined, and the contact did not continue.

The scheme itself is well documented publicly: a cold DM offering to buy a username outside Fragment is a known pretext that, in documented cases, escalates into session hijacking through a fake QR code or a requested SMS code framed as "proof of ownership" or "payment confirmation." In this case the contact never reached that stage, so the downstream steps described below are reconstructed from external sources rather than directly observed.

2. Observed contact

- Account: display name "BlockRider", username @BlockRider454, Telegram Premium
- Bio: "Collector of usernames" — preemptively answers the target's first question about why a stranger is reaching out
- Phone number country: Sweden (+46); account registration: April 2026
- In the chat the sender introduced himself as "Thomas" — matching neither the display name nor the username
- The offer text was generic, with no price, no marketplace reference, and no proof of funds
- The attacker's own username is a random numeric suffix, which contradicts the claimed "collector" persona — genuine username traders typically showcase a portfolio of clean handles

3. Why this is especially risky for people with a public, reputation-bearing identity

This scheme is usually discussed in a crypto context, where a username is treated as a resellable asset. For someone who uses Telegram as a working channel with sources, journalists, NGOs and partners, the consequences are different.

- The real loss is not the username but trust in the identifier. Whoever takes over the account can message sources, colleagues and contacts at vulnerable organizations while posing as the owner.
- Access to chat history is access to sources. For an investigative account, the message history itself is valuable — it can deanonymize contacts and expose collection methods.
- A public username already hands the attacker a target list. If it appears in reports, a byline, or a contact line, no additional reconnaissance is needed.
- The scheme can be mass and untargeted and still be dangerous if it happens to land on a visible account: there is no targeting, but the impact is still high.

4. Risk chain on successful execution (per the documented pattern)

Stage	What is lost
Loss of the username	A minor inconvenience — a new handle can be set
Loss of the session (QR or code handed over)	Access to chat history, contacts and messages until the session is rotated
Impersonation	Messages sent as the owner — the risk now falls on the recipients
Reputational damage	Sources and partners lose trust after receiving messages "from you"

Secondary exploitation	The compromised account becomes a launch point for attacking its contacts
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Most of the damage lands on the victim's contact network, not on the victim. Response therefore cannot stop at securing one's own account: any suspicion of compromise should trigger a fast warning to contacts.

5. Observed red flags

- Cold contact with no price, no marketplace reference, and no proof of funds
- Offer to conduct the deal outside Fragment
- A recently registered account with Premium status — commonly used to build trust and bypass limits on messaging strangers
- A bio that pre-explains the reason for the cold contact, defusing the target's first objection
- Identity inconsistencies: the name used in chat does not match the display name/username, and there is no portfolio or channel showing a deal history
- The attacker's own username is a random string of digits despite claiming to be a collector or trader

6. Indicators (IOC)

Type	Value
Telegram username	@BlockRider454
Telegram display name	BlockRider
Telegram bio	Collector of usernames

The username is the least stable of these indicators — Telegram allows handles to be changed and recycled, so it may be short-lived. The display name and bio text are a more durable pattern for matching similar future contacts.

7. MITRE ATT&CK

ID	Technique
T1585.001	Establish Accounts: Social Media Accounts — persona created for the contact
T1656	Impersonation — the claimed name "Thomas" does not match the profile
T1598.003	Phishing for Information: Spearphishing via Service — cold outreach via Telegram DM
T1539	Steal Web Session Cookie — documented next stage of the pattern (QR/session hijack); not observed in this contact
T1078	Valid Accounts — documented impersonation via a hijacked account; not observed in this contact

8. Recommendations

8.1. For individuals with a public research identifier

- Do not negotiate a username sale outside Fragment. A genuine offer should go through the marketplace.
- Never authenticate via a QR code or read out an SMS code for "proof of ownership" or "payment." This is always a session hijack attempt.
- Enable Two-Step Verification and a cloud password — do not rely on SMS alone.
- Periodically review Active Sessions and terminate immediately on any unexpected login code.
- Hide your phone number and restrict calls and group additions to contacts only.
- Keep a separate recovery channel — email plus 2FA/passkey, not just a phone number.

8.2. For organizations and contact networks

- Agree in advance on a fallback way to verify identity — a code word, a second communication channel. Set this up before an incident, not after.
- Verify any unusual message from a known contact through a different channel, especially if it asks for money, a link, or data.

9. Sources

- p05h, "Sophisticated Telegram Based Scam Designed to Fool Fragment Users," Medium, 2024-11 — medium.com/@p05h/sophisticated-telegram-based-scam-designed-to-fool-fragment-users-7d06334db111
- "The Telegram Username Scam: How People Are Losing Thousands in TON," DEV Community, 2025-07 — dev.to/scofieldidehen/the-telegram-username-scam-how-people-are-losing-thousands-in-ton-140n
- Authors' own observation, August 20, 2026

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